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Belief and Value Change Among University Students

A METU-Based Study

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Aim of the Study

The aim of this study is to examine changes and variations in the beliefs and values of university students by taking multiple factors into account more specifically focusing on their personal backgrounds and the experiences they acquired during their time at METU campus life. The research seeks to understand how the university environment and individuals' personal backgrounds contribute to this process of change. In addition, it analyzes the relationship between the value frameworks students adopt, the factors that lead to these orientations, and the consistency between their values and everyday practices. In doing so, the study demonstrates that the formation of value-based identity is not a one-dimensional phenomenon but a complex, multi-layered process.

Introduction

The university period is not solely a process in which individuals acquire academic knowledge; it is also a critical threshold where belief and value systems inherited from the family are questioned and individual identity is reshaped. In social psychology and educational sociology, this stage is often described as the "critical years," as it marks a transition from a relatively homogeneous family environment to a more diverse and heterogeneous university setting. One of the most significant outcomes of this transition is the change experienced in individuals' belief systems and ethical values.

The present study examines how the sociocultural opportunities offered by the METU campus environment shape students' beliefs and values from an "impact–response" perspective with a particular emphasis on the role of personal background. While existing literature generally limits the impact of university education on secularization or belief change to formal education and its duration, this research adopts a broader approach. It considers both university life as a social cultural experience and the role of personal backgrounds in shaping belief-oriented identities. Moreover, it examines the distribution of beliefs and values across demographic factors and explores the contradictions between students' values and everyday practices

Survey, Participants and Data Collection

This survey was conducted online and anonymously, exclusively for METU students. Our survey contained a total of 36 questions. Eight of these questions were introductory, while 25 were Likert scale questions focusing on family, past experiences, the university environment, and experiences at the university. The remaining three questions were designed to ask participants to rank certain factors related to their beliefs from their own perspective. The survey took an average of 5 minutes and 36 seconds to complete. A total of 123 people participated in our study. The survey was sent to 300 people and completed by 123. The main reasons for the 59% non-response rate were interpreted as the large number of surveys conducted on campus and the resulting disinterest of students. The respondents were mostly individuals we contacted directly to complete the survey. The survey used a 5-point Likert scale ranging from "Agree" to

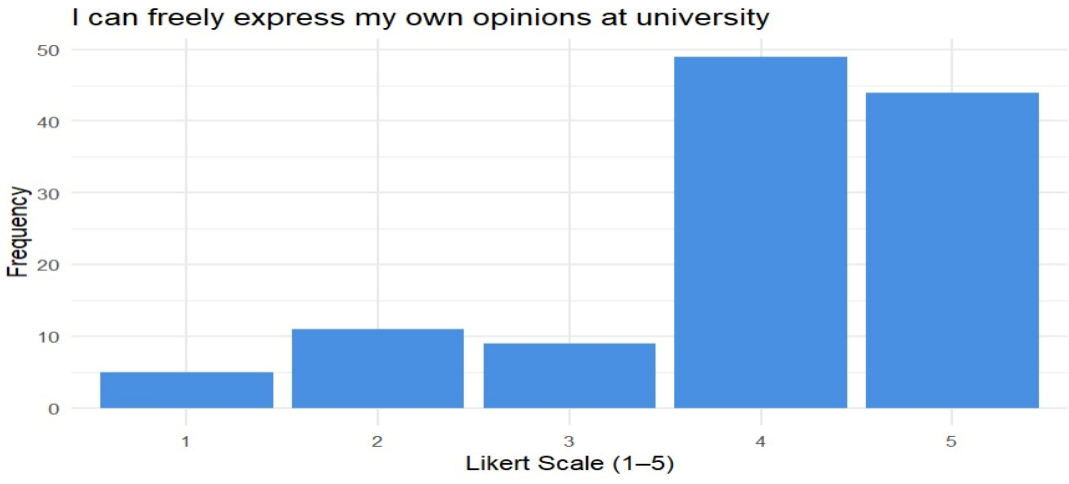
“Disagree” to examine the factors influencing students' pre-university experiences and changes in their beliefs about university.

Data Desciption

Kategori	Değişkenler
University Climate	uni_farkli_gorus, uni_sorgulama, uni_ifade_ozgurluk, uni_saygi, uni_hosgoru, uni_deger_yeniden, uni_bakis_acisi, insanlari_bagimsiz_yargi
Belief/Value Transformation	uni_deger_yeniden, uni_varolussal, cocuk_farkli_saygi, inanc_turu, inanc_faktor_oncelik,
Social Dimension	farkli_iliskide_rahat, romantik_inanc_onem, farkli_inanc_iletisim,metafizik_gorus
External Influences	aile_inanc_konusur, aile_fikir_destek, aile_etki, lise_arkadas_etki, lise_ogretmen_etki, lise_saygi, lise_sorgulama, lise_inanca_gore_yargi, lise_ifade_ozgurluk, aile_en_cok_etki

Exploring Campus Habitus Through Students’ Perspectives

1.) Freedom of Thought and Expression of university

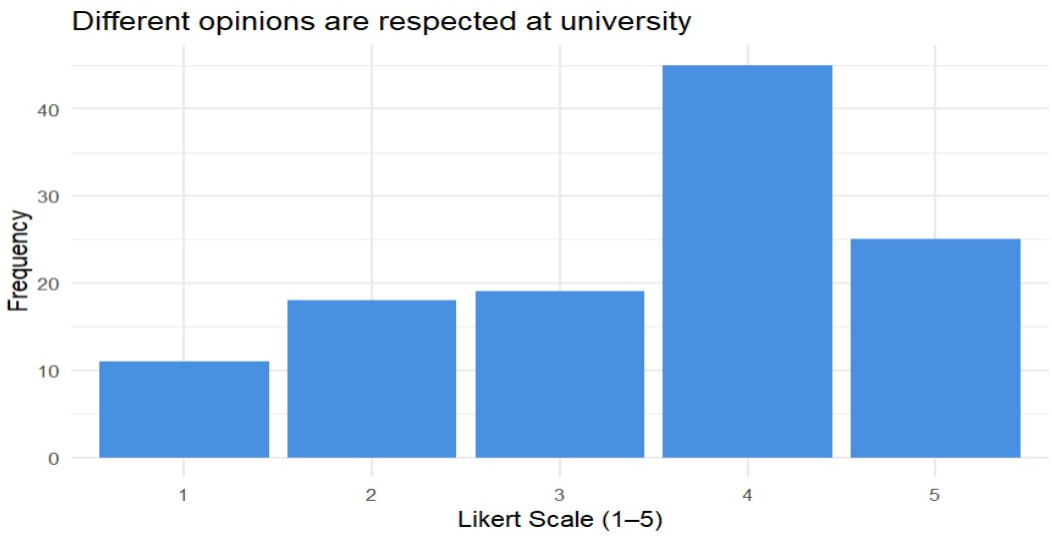


'I can freely express my own opinions at university.' (%)

1	2	3	4	5
4.2	9.3	7.6	41.5	37.3

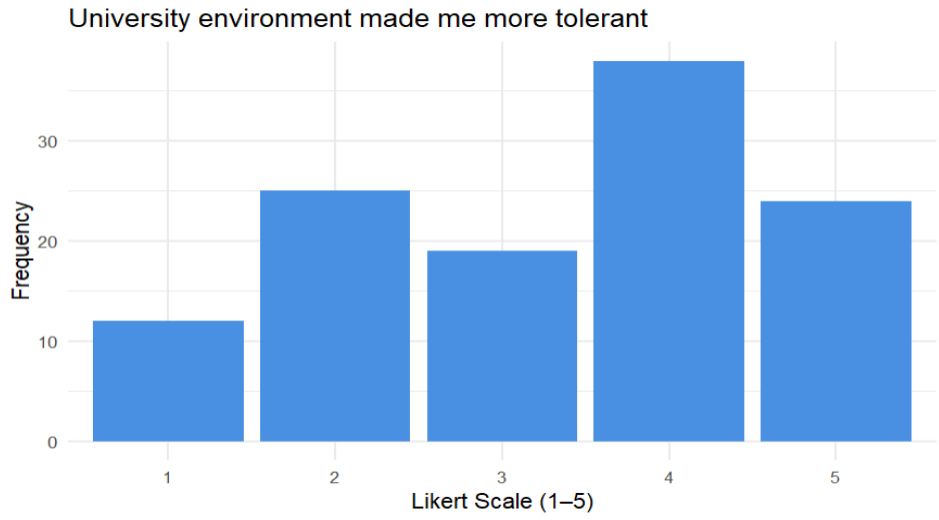
Responses are strongly concentrated at the higher end of the scale, suggesting that most students experience the university as a space where self-expression is largely possible. This points to a campus habitus that encourages speaking up rather than self-censorship. Moreoever, the university environment may fosters a democratic culture of discussion.

2. Different opinions are respected at university



While agreement remains dominant, the distribution is more spread out compared to self-expression. This indicates that although students may feel free to express themselves, the perception of mutual respect is less uniform across the campus.

3. University environment made me more tolerant

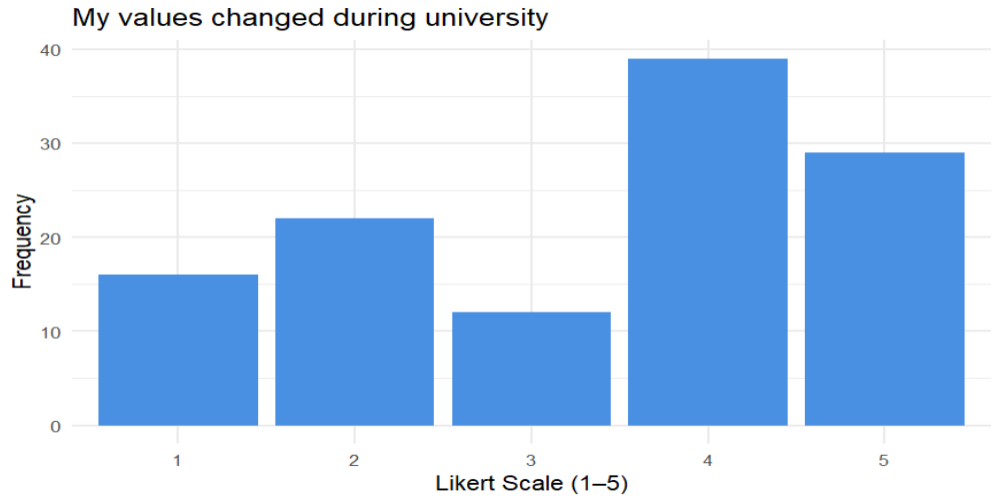


'University environment made me more tolerant' (%)

1	2	3	4	5
10.2	21.2	16.1	32.2	20.3

It is evident that one of the most substantial social ramifications of education is the extent of an individual's tolerance. It is the contention of 52.5% of students that their university experience has engendered a greater degree of tolerance on the part of the students themselves. The presence of individuals from diverse backgrounds has facilitated students' encounters with "the other", fostering an environment conducive to the cultivation of tolerance. However, the fact that approximately 31% of participants were undecided or negative on this issue suggests that there is a necessity for increased campus interaction.

4. Change of values during university years

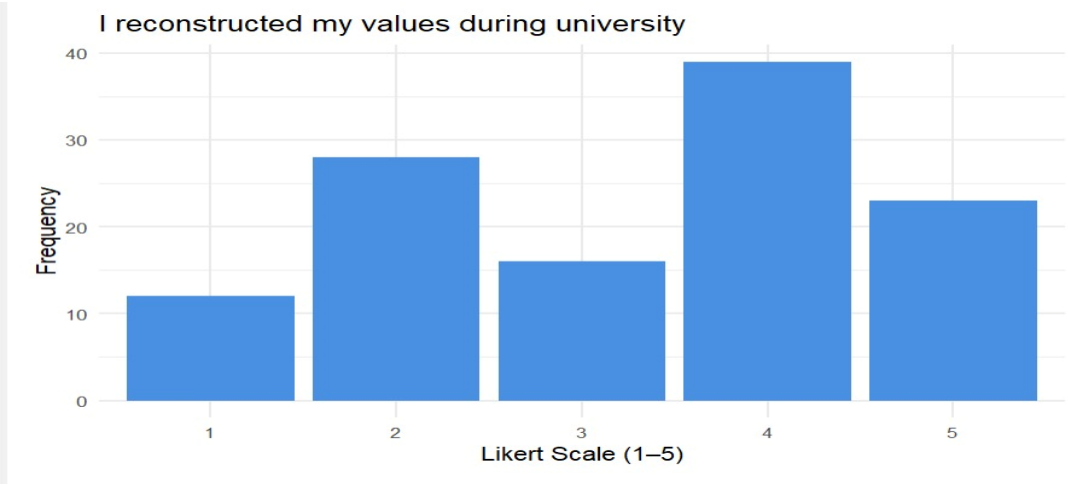


'My values changed during university' (%)

1	2	3	4	5
13.6	18.6	10.2	33.1	24.6

Responses are heavily concentrated at the higher end of the scale, with a clear majority selecting 4 or 5. This indicates that for most students, university is experienced as a period of substantial value change rather than minor adjustment, pointing to a campus environment that plays a meaningful role in reshaping personal orientations.

5. Reconstruction of Values during university years.



In the context of organisational transformation, a key aspect of strategic management is the conscious reconstruction of values. Furthermore, 52.6% of participants indicated that they had undergone a process of "reconstruction" of their values during their university years. This finding, which is consistent with the "change" data, suggests that a significant proportion of the students questioned the values they had previously held and established a more conscious, deliberate value system.

Taken together, these patterns suggest that university functions as an active arena where students question, adjust, and at times fundamentally reconstruct their values. The campus appears to provide a social and intellectual climate that makes such reflection and change possible. Having established this exploratory picture, the next step is to look beneath the surface: to examine how family backgrounds shape these processes and to ask not only how much change occurs, but also in which direction and under what conditions values are most likely to shift.

Family Backgrounds and the Direction of Value Change

Methodology: Binary logistic regression models were estimated using family religious communication as the key predictor, as it best captures the family's religious orientation. High value change and value reconstruction were operationalized by recoding Likert responses 4–5 as 1 and all others as 0. In addition, respondents who reported full reconstruction (5) were filtered, and their stated most important influencing factor was summarized using a proportional table.

1.Talking at Home, Changing at Campus

Family Religious Communication and Value Change:

Family conversations matter. A binary logistic regression shows that more frequent communication about religious beliefs within the family significantly increases the likelihood of experiencing a high level of value change during university ($\beta = 0.53$, $p = .001$). Substantively, each one-unit increase in family communication raises the odds of major value change by about **71%**.
In other words, students who grow up talking about religion at home are more likely to question, revise, and rethink their values once they encounter the intellectual and social diversity of university life. Rather than fixing beliefs in place, family discussion appears to *activate* them.

2. When Change Becomes Reconstruction

From Adjustment to Deep Transformation

The effect of family religious communication extends beyond general change to more radical outcomes. A second logistic model indicates that family communication also predicts the **complete reconstruction of values** ($\beta = 0.42$, $p = .050$), increasing the odds by roughly **52%**.
However, this is where the story gets interesting. Qualitative responses show that **personal experiences**, followed by peer environments and living away from family, are the most frequently cited triggers of full reconstruction. This suggests a layered process: family communication prepares the ground, but lived experiences on campus pull the trigger. Family acts as the background script; university life writes the plot.

Factors Influencing Individuals Who Reconstructed Their Values During University

Influencing.Factor	Frequency	Percentage (%)
Kişisel deneyimler	41	66.1
Arkadaş çevresi	8	12.9
Aileden uzak yaşamak	4	6.5
Akademik ortam	4	6.5
Kitaplar/filmler	3	4.8
Romantik ilişki	1	1.6
Sosyal medya	1	1.6

3. Change, But Not All the Way Out

Why Talking Religion Doesn't Lead to Atheism

The third model reveals a counterintuitive but crucial finding. Family religious communication significantly *reduces* the likelihood of identifying as atheist or agnostic ($\beta = -0.54$, $p = .001$). Each unit increase in communication lowers the odds of atheist or agnostic identification by about **42%**.
Put simply, students from families where religion is openly discussed are more likely to change and even reconstruct their beliefs, but less likely to abandon belief altogether. Family dialogue seems to encourage active reflection while simultaneously anchoring individuals within a religious framework.

What This Tells Us

Taken together, these findings show that family religious communication plays a **dual role** in students' religious trajectories. It increases openness to questioning, change, and even deep transformation, while also limiting the likelihood of a complete exit from belief. Family background does not dictate outcomes, but it shapes the *conditions* under which change unfolds. In short, beliefs are neither simply inherited nor freely chosen, they are negotiated at the intersection of family conversations and campus experiences.

Analysis By Demographics

This section summarizes demographic variations in students' exposure to diverse beliefs, tolerance, and value-related attitudes. Although the survey included multiple demographic variables, meaningful differences were limited. Accordingly, this section focuses only on findings that are statistically noticeable and substantively informative. The analysis highlights patterns related to generation and gender, using descriptive statistics and appropriate inferential tests to identify where noteworthy differences emerge.

By Generation:

Generational Patterns in Exposure and Tolerance

Mean scores for exposure to different beliefs and perceived tolerance are presented below by generational cohort, using university year as a proxy for generation:

Year	Exposure Mean	Exposure SD	Tolerance Mean	Tolerance SD
1	4.50	0.58	4.25	1.50
2	3.69	1.49	3.31	1.38
3	3.82	1.19	3.41	1.18

4	3.97	1.26	3.11	1.39
5	4.20	1.11	3.31	1.30
6	3.70	1.25	3.10	1.37
8	3.71	1.25	2.71	1.25

Earlier cohorts display slightly higher average scores in both exposure and tolerance; however, these differences do not follow a consistent linear pattern. This suggests that generational variation exists but does not point to a clear or systematic shift across cohorts.

Belief Type Distribution Across Generations

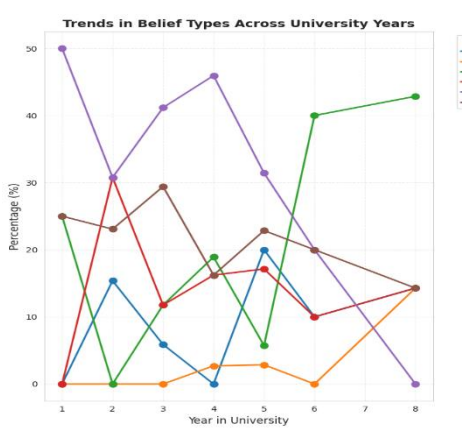
Methodology: To examine whether belief types differ across generations, a chi-square test of independence was conducted using **generation (proxied by university year)** and belief type. The test yielded a chi-square statistic of 34.93 with 30 degrees of freedom ($p = 0.245$).

Generation	God.exists.but.does.not.intervene	Other	Existence.as.divine.whole	No.divine.power	Personal.God	Not.sure
1	0	0	25	0	50	25
2	15.4	0	0	30.8	30.8	23.1
3	5.9	0	11.8	11.8	41.2	29.4
4	0	2.7	18.9	16.2	45.9	16.2
5	20	2.9	5.7	17.1	31.4	22.9
6	10	0	40	10	20	20
8	14.3	14.3	42.9	14.3	0	14.3

The result is not statistically significant, indicating no observable differences in belief type distributions across generations in this sample. Given the cross-sectional design and the use of university year as a generational proxy, this finding should not be interpreted as evidence of belief stability over time. Rather, it suggests that no clear **cohort-based or generational differences** in belief systems are detectable.

Generational Trends in Individual Belief Types

Methodology: Spearman rank-order correlation tests were conducted to examine whether the prevalence of specific belief types shows monotonic change across generations.



No belief category exhibited a statistically significant correlation with generation. In short, no belief type stands out as becoming more or less prevalent across cohorts. While distributions vary, none of the beliefs emerge as systematically gaining or losing prominence over time.

Correlations Between University Year and Other Variables (Contextual Note):

Correlations between university year and various Likert-scale variables (1-5) examined to identify which factors are associated with generations or progression through university.

In the course of this exploration, one statistically significant correlation was identified ($p < 0.05$):

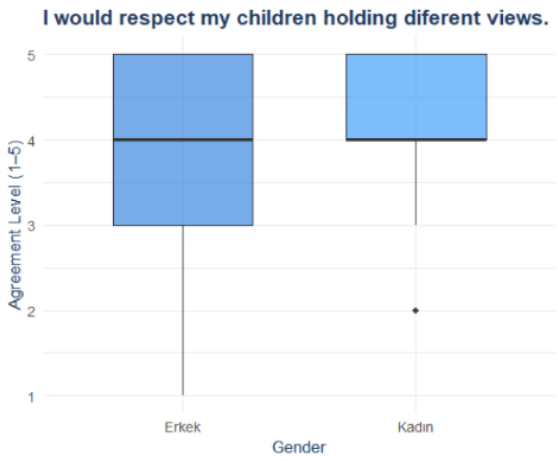
Variable	Correlation	p-value
aile_sosyoekonomik	-0.2020	0.0251

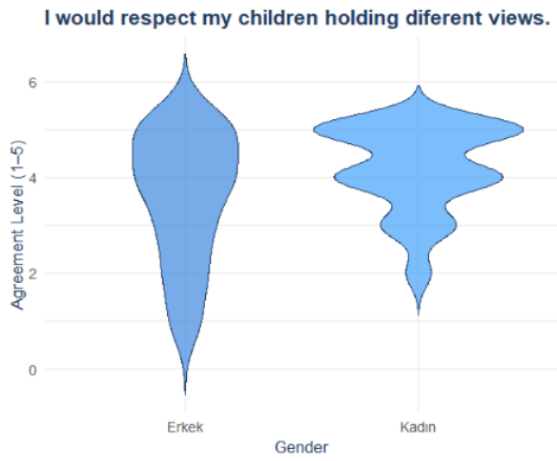
At this stage of the analysis, **university year is no longer interpreted as a generational proxy**, but rather as an indicator of **time spent within higher education**. A weak but statistically significant negative correlation was observed between university year and family socioeconomic status ($r = -0.20$, $p = 0.025$). This suggests that students in higher university years tend to report slightly lower family socioeconomic status. Although this falls outside the primary focus of the report, the pattern is consistent with broader discussions that access to and persistence in higher education are shaped by class-based dynamics. That said, given the small effect size and the cross-sectional nature of the data, this observation should be treated as a suggestive contextual note rather than a central finding.

By Gender:

Methodology: As part of a comprehensive survey incorporating multiple Likert-type questions (rated on a 1–5 scale), gender differences were examined across all variables. Group comparisons were conducted using Mann–Whitney U tests, independent-samples t-tests, and ordinal logistic regression models. Six variables consistently exhibited statistically significant(0.05 level) gender differences across all three analytical approaches; the present section reports three of these variables, selected for their substantive relevance.

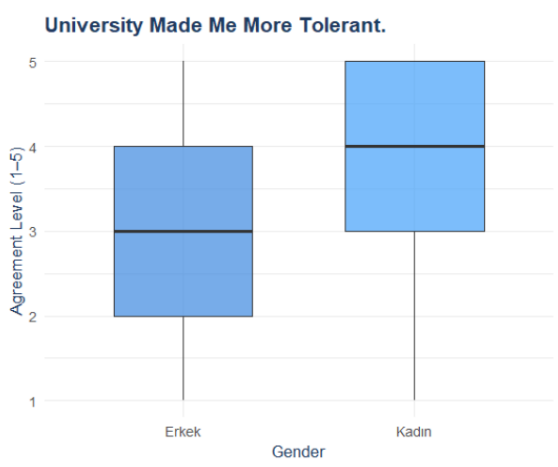
Respect for Children Holding Different Views

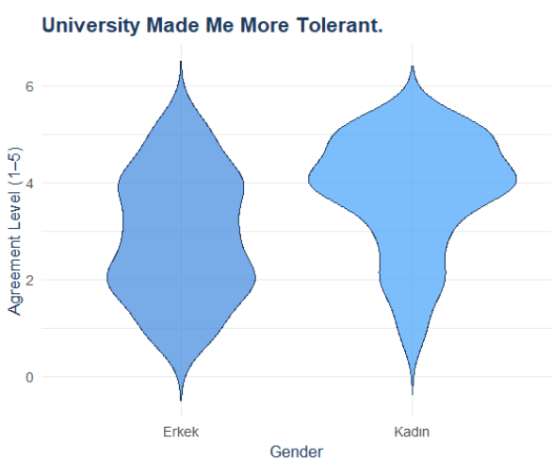




The Mann–Whitney U test indicated a statistically significant difference between female and male students ($p < .05$), and this finding was supported by the ordinal logistic regression results, which showed that female students had significantly higher odds of assigning stronger respect to children holding different beliefs compared to male students (OR = 2.20, $p = .02$). A visual inspection of the boxplot and violin plot indicates that women's responses are more concentrated in the higher agreement categories (levels 4–5), whereas men's responses display a wider dispersion, extending further into lower agreement levels. The findings of this study indicate that, on average, female participants reported stronger endorsement of respecting children's differing views compared to male participants.

University Experience and Increased Tolerance



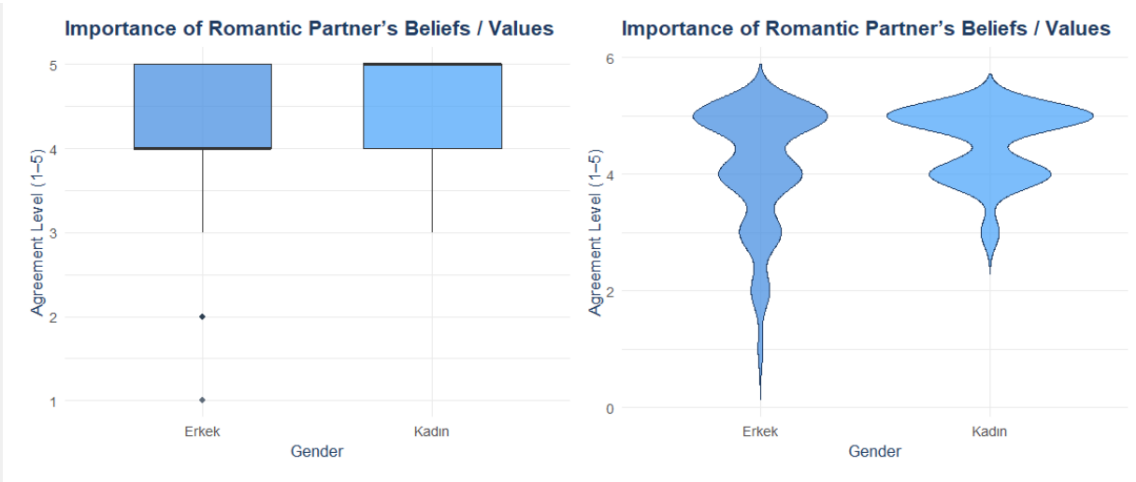


A statistical analysis of the responses given by the students revealed a gender difference that was statistically significant in terms of perceptions regarding the manner in which the university experience contributes to an increase in tolerance. The results from all applied tests consistently

indicate strong statistical evidence for this difference ($p < .001$). Ordinal logistic regression analysis demonstrated that female students exhibited a greater propensity to report higher levels of agreement with the statement that their university experience increased tolerance (OR = 3.74) in comparison to their male counterparts.

Distributional patterns further suggested that women's responses tended to cluster towards higher agreement categories, whereas men's responses were more concentrated around moderate levels. The findings of this study indicate that, among the student population, women demonstrate a greater propensity to perceive the university experience as playing a significant role in fostering tolerance when compared to men.

Importance of a Romantic Partner's Beliefs and Values



A

modest yet statistically significant gender discrepancy was identified for the item "The beliefs and values of my romantic partner are important to me" ($p < .05$). Across the range of analytical approaches employed, women exhibited a tendency to report slightly higher levels of agreement in comparison to men, a pattern that was corroborated by ordinal logistic regression analysis (OR = 2.04). While there was a high level of agreement among students of both genders, women's responses were more consistently located in the higher categories, whereas men's responses exhibited greater variability.

It is noteworthy that this finding coexists with women's higher tolerance for belief differences in broader social and developmental contexts. This pattern suggests that women individuals may be receptive to diversity in general, yet place greater emphasis on shared values in close personal relationships.

Gender Differences in Atheist or Agnostic Identification

Methodology: To examine gender differences in atheist/agnostic identification, probabilities were estimated using maximum likelihood estimation (MLE), and group differences were assessed using a Wald test.

Gender	Count	Percentage
Male	26 / 61	42%
Female	20 / 57	35%

The survey revealed that approximately 42% of male respondents (26 out of 61) and 35% of female respondents (20 out of 57) identified as atheist/agnostic. The gender composition of the sample is nearly balanced, with comparable numbers of men and women included in the analysis. However, despite this observed difference in percentages, the Wald test results indicate that the difference is not statistically significant, suggesting that atheist identification **does not meaningfully differ** between men and women in this sample.

To summarize this section,

Demographic differences are generally limited. Generational variation in exposure and tolerance exists but shows no clear or systematic pattern, and belief type distributions do not differ significantly across cohorts, nor do any specific beliefs display generational trends. Interpreting university year as time in higher education reveals a weak negative association with family socioeconomic status. Gender differences are more pronounced: women report higher respect for children's differing views, greater perceived increases in tolerance through university, However, they put less tolerance on a romantic partner's beliefs. Moreover, atheist/agnostic identification does not significantly differ by gender.

The Entertaining Contradictions of Student Beliefs

Objective: This section will examine the consistency between students' self-identified belief labels (e.g. theist, atheist, or deist) and their participation in different metaphysical practices. The objective of this study is to ascertain whether students adopt a "hybrid" belief system, or whether the adoption of a particular label (e.g. "Deist") results in a complete rejection of traditional religious practices (e.g. prayer).

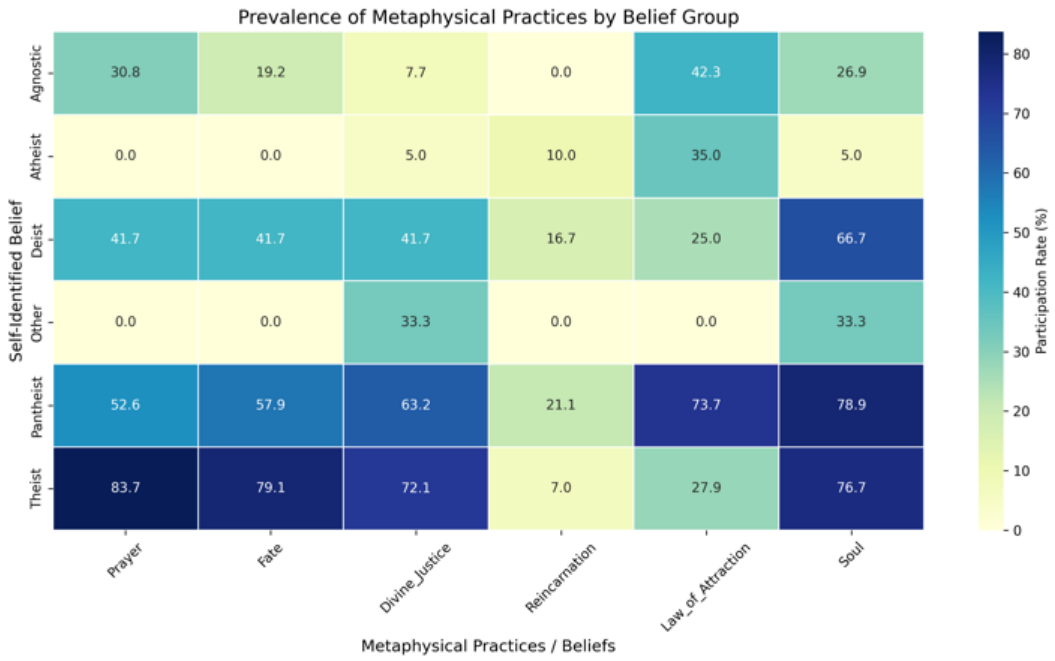
Methodology : We categorized respondents into six belief groups: Theist, Atheist, Agnostic, Deist, Pantheist, and Other. We then analyzed their participation in six metaphysical practices: Prayer, Fate , Divine Justice, Reincarnation, Law of Attraction, and Soul.

- **Descriptive Statistics**: Used to calculate participation percentages

- **Chi-Square Test of Independence**: Used to determine whether the relationship between belief labels and practices is statistically significant or not.

Chi-Square Test Results: With one noticeable exception, the statistical analysis showed significant relationships for the majority of practices:

- **Significant Relationships ($p<0.05$):** Prayer ($p=0.00$), Fate ($p=0.00$), Divine Justice ($p=0.00$), Soul ($p=0.00$), and Law of Attraction ($p=0.01$).
- **Non-Significant Relationship:** Reincarnation ($p=0.19$).



1.Cultural Memory and the "Deist Paradox"

"Deist Paradox"

The main finding is the difference between the behavior of Deist students and the philosophical notion of Deism (a non-intervening creator).

- **41.7%** of Deists still engage in **Prayer** and believe in **Fate.**

- **66.7%** of people believe that souls exist. This implies that "**Deism**" is not a total denial of spiritual connection, but rather a way for many students to distance themselves from organized religion. Despite changing their title, they continue to practice cultural-religious customs.

2.Atheists and Agnostics' Secular Spirituality

While Atheists consistently rejected traditional concepts (0% for Prayer and Fate), they showed interest to the modern spiritual concepts, which is suprising.

- **35%** of Atheists and **42.3%** of Agnostics believe in the Law of Attraction. This indicates a shift towards "secular spirituality," where individuals reject a personified God but still looking for a connection to a greater cosmic order or energy system.

3.The Agnostic Dilemma: Prayer as a Coping Mechanism

Despite their doubts regarding the existence of a god, **30.8%** of Agnostics pray, which is an interesting psychological finding. In contrast to atheism, agnosticism's uncertainty causes prayer to function as a stress-reduction strategy rather than a dogmatic habit. This is probably due to "**cultural habituation**" in which comforting rituals remain in spite of skepticism, or a pragmatic response to uncertainty similar to Pascal's wager (betting on God's existence to minimize risk).

4.Pantheists as "Holistic Believers"

Pantheists had the highest scores in the **Law of Attraction** (73.7%) and **Soul** (78.9%), as was to be expected. This information demonstrates how inclusive they are, effectively combining traditional religious ideas with modern-day views without causing internal conflict.

Conclusion The findings of this study show that university students' self-identified belief labels and their real metaphysical practices differ significantly. According to the research, belief is not a fixed category but rather a spectrum that is defined by "**cultural retention**" and "**secular spirituality**".

The "**Deist Paradox**" in which students maintain rituals like prayer despite theoretically rejecting supernatural involvement, is the best example of this. Similarly, the "**Agnostic Dilemma**" emphasizes how, despite dogmatic certainty, prayer frequently endures as a psychological coping strategy or cultural habit.

Moreover, the rise of "**Secular Spirituality**" among Agnostics and Atheists, which takes the form of faith in the Law of Attraction, shows that rejecting a personal God does not mean rejecting a greater cosmic order. Pantheists, on the other hand, exhibit a "**holistic synthesis**" effectively integrating traditional and modern ideas.

Summary and Conclusions

Our study has shown that our university is an environment of free thought where different ideas are respected, and that the majority of students shape their beliefs and values during their campus life and university years. When we examined the reasons behind this, we found that although students stated that their personal experiences were dominant, the influence of the family demonstrated an undeniable correlation. Due to ethical concerns, we could not directly ask individuals about their family environments or their families' views; however, through a set of questions, we indirectly measured these factors and revealed the extent to which individuals' past experiences affect their identities, even if they are not consciously aware of it. So much so that, although children of families strongly attached to belief values go through more change,

transformation, and questioning, they still cannot completely break away from the patterns they carry from the past.

Moreover, we examined generational and demographic differences between men and women and discovered certain distinctions. While women are more tolerant toward their social environments than men, this tolerance decreases toward romantic partners, and we found that women give importance on sharing the same views more than men do. No significant difference between generations was observed.

Finally, by demonstrating the contradiction between how students define their own value-based identities and their daily practices, and by drawing on concepts such as the "Deist Paradox," the "Agnostic Dilemma," and the rise of "secular spirituality," we showed that belief labels often fail to fully represent lived metaphysical behaviors. These findings suggest that cultural memory, habitual practices, and psychological coping mechanisms continue to shape individuals' actions beyond their consciously adopted belief frameworks. In this sense, we revealed the conflict between the individual's conscious and unconscious (subconscious) mind and emotions, and once again brought to mind the question of whether free will truly exists.